Gap to capture the airfield, the corps commander pointed out that Chushul was a screening position and that the defence of Leh was of paramount importance. Accordingly, the corps commander ordered 114 Brigade to pull back from the entire line of defence and occupy fresh defences along the range west of Chushul. 114 Brigade was tasked with moving all heavy equipment out of the area so that it would not fall into Chinese hands.

During the entire battle of Chushul, 13 Field Regiment had played a major, if not crucial part. While one troop was deployed at High Ground near Brigade HQ, the second troop was deployed in support of Mugger Hill. After the battle of Rezang-la, the Chinese came down from that direction with the intention of neutralizing the Indian guns. Even as the decision to withdraw was being taken, the guns were attacked. The gunners fired over open sights directly into the mass of the assaulting Chinese, forcing them to quickly pull back. As they were withdrawing, the Indian gunners saw some Chinese self-propelled guns moving into the Spanggur Gap. In what would be the last act of defiance in the Chushul sector, the gunners engaged the Chinese guns, blowing one of them to bits with a direct hit.

THE FINAL SLAP (NEW DELHI) 18-19 NOVEMBER

For General Pran Thapar, it was the end of the road. As the gigantic 4-engined IAF Super Constellation flew westward towards New Delhi, Thapar sat with Brigadier Palit in grim silence. The DMO was busy putting down from memory the notes he had handed over to Kaul at the Tezpur airfield. After a while, the chief motioned to Palit to sit closer to him. Stepping across the aisle, he sat down on the armrest of the seat. Thapar reached across and clasped the younger man’s hand, tears rolling down his cheeks. For a few minutes, the two officers just sat quietly, sharing their misery and distress. The 4th Indian Division, on whose shoulders the entire defence of NEFA had been entrusted, had folded up and withdrawn without even facing the main thrust of the Chinese.

After he had composed himself, Thapar sought Palit’s advice, asking him point-blank if he should ‘step down’. Palit did not immediately reply. ‘I consulted Bijji this morning,’ Thapar added, ‘he was emphatic that there was no call for me to resign—and that I must not think of taking such a step. Now I am not too sure; and I would like your frank opinion.’

‘Sir, all of us—the Prime Minister, the government, Army HQ and the generals in the field—all must shoulder the blame for the operational trap